The Production of Black Ph.Ds. in Economics at Harvard University,1905-1955

Lawrence Karongo
McNair Scholar

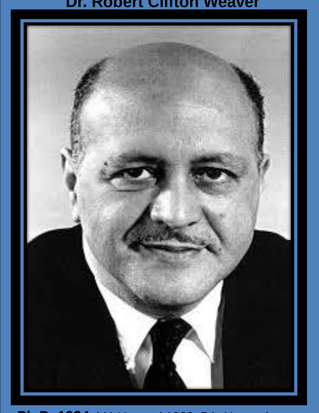
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Dr. Samuel L. Myers Jr.

Abstract

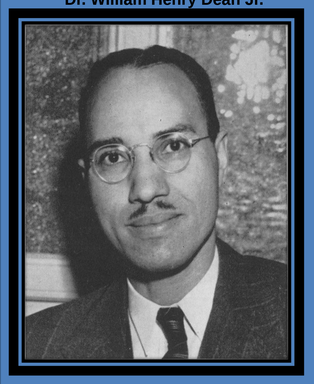
This paper analyzes the determinants of the production of black Ph.Ds. in economics at Harvard, between 1905 and 1955. Harvard University's economics program arguably was the leading graduate economics program in the world in the first half of the 20th Century. It had the distinction of producing more African American economists than any other program during the period. Who were these black recipients of the economics doctorate at Harvard? What factors explain their success in obtaining one of the most coveted degrees in academia? Using historical records, the paper examines: who they were, what they did after receiving their doctorates, and the significance of their life's accomplishments. A logistic model was established using data on doctoral awards from 1905 to 1955 to identify the determinants of the production of black economists. Results show that the main factor influencing the production of black Ph.Ds. was the coveted Julius Rosenwald Fellowship, followed by dissertations on theory.

Dr. Robert Clifton Weaver



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Dr. William Henry Dean Jr.



Ph.D. 1938, MA Harvard 1932; BA, Bowdoin 1928; Fredrick Douglas High School, Baltimore MD. Professor of Economics Atlanta University, 1933-1942, Director of community relations National Urban League, 1944-1946; United Nations Africa Unit Chief, 1949-1952

Dr. Booker Tanner McGraw



Ph.D. 1939, MA, MBA University of Michigan,1923, 1924; MA, Harvard 1934; Instructor of Economics Lincoln University, 1924; Assistant to the Administrator, Housing and Home Finance Agency, 1961-1963

Introduction

- **Purpose**: To model the determinants of the production of black economists from Harvard between 1905-1955
- **Specific Aims:**
  - Document the historical patterns and factors attendant to the production of black economists at a leading economics department
  - Determine the relative importance of external scholarships and financial assistance
  - Examine the significance of the Julius Rosenwald Fellowship in producing black economists
  - Detail background factors of black scholars predicting their success as national leaders
- **Hypothesis:** ***Recipiency of the Julius Rosenwald Fellowship is associated with higher probabilities that a Harvard Ph.D. in economics is Black.***
  - Julius Rosenwald-Major philanthropist,
  - Rosenwald Foundation- Supporter of Harlem Renaissance writers and intellectuals; provider of scholarship support for areas of need
- **Significance**: *First empirical documentation of the background and origin of the original six blacks to receive Ph.Ds. in Economics at Harvard; First statistical analysis of the determinates of black Ph.D. recipients in economics at Harvard.*

Methodology

- Reviewed literature regarding blacks at Harvard and the economics department
- Created data set of 609 economics Ph.D. recipients from the *Quinquennial Catologue of Officers and Graduates, (1636-1930)* and Harvard/Radcliffe Annual Reports (1930-1955)
- Identified: first and last name, graduation year, undergraduate and graduate institution(s), title of dissertation, occupation, Rosenwald Fellowship
- Created explanatory variables: Southern undergraduate institutions, Harvard undergraduate, Relative class size, Theory Dissertation, Rosenwald Fellowship
- Performed t-test for difference in means via STATA **(Figure1)**
- Obtained maximum estimates in logistic model of the probability of a black recipient; x=variables, R=Fellowship

$$p(b_t \mid x_t; R) = \frac{1}{1 + e^{-\sum B_{it} \cdot X_{it} - \emptyset_t \cdot R_t}}$$

- Computed elsasticities of P(b) with respect to X's and Rosenwald Fellowship:

$$\varepsilon_{b,X} = \frac{\partial p(b)}{\partial Xi} \cdot \frac{X_i}{p(b)} = (1 - p) \cdot \hat{B}_i \bar{X}_i$$

Results

Figure 1

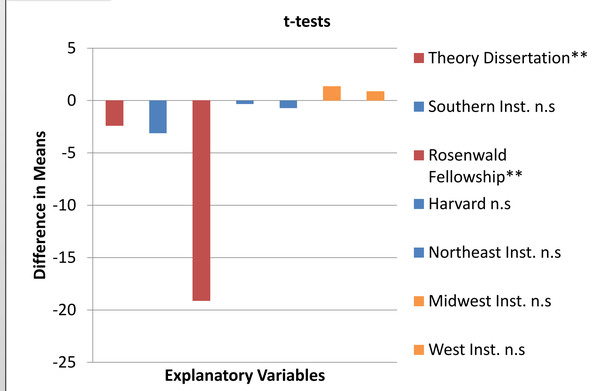


Figure 2

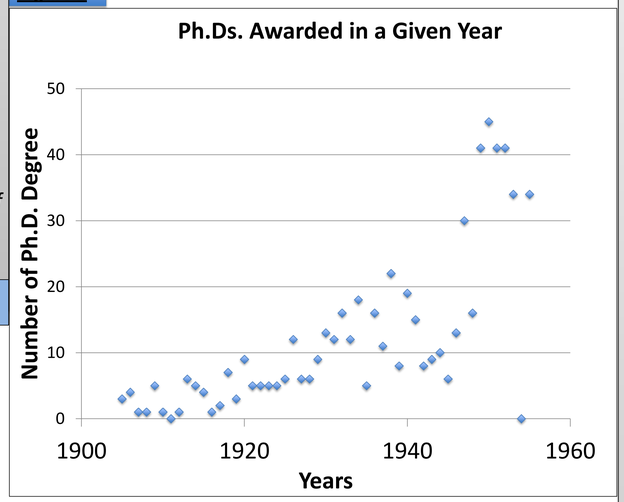


Table 1

Logistic Regression

Log pseudo likelihood=	Number of obs=609	Wald chi2(4)=		Psuedo R2 =	Prob>chi2= 0.00000
-15.459095		43.13		0.5411	

Variable:	Coef.	Robust Std. Err	z	P>|z|	[95% Conf.	Interval]
Theory	2.415164	1.168123	2.07	0.039	0.1256851	4.704642
RosenwaldF	7.369026	2.050893	3.59	0.000	3.34935	11.3887
Harvard	1.757303	1.356362	1.3	0.195	-0.9011173	4.415723
Relative Size	-19.5808	19.40743	-1.01	0.313	-57.61867	18.45706
Constant	-6.16125	1.084137	-5.68	0.000	-8.286115	-4.03638

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Purpose of Study

- To determine number of Harvard black Ph.D. recipients between 1905 and 1955.
- To document the lives and times of all black Ph.Ds. in economics at Harvard University from 1905-1955
- To examine the factors that contributed to black representation among Harvard doctorates in economics

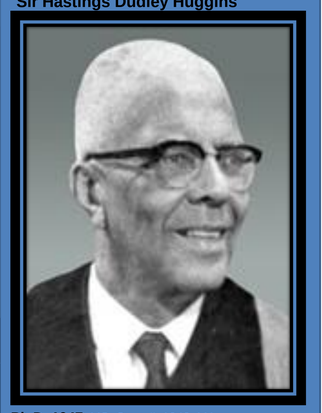
Discussion

- After 1930, there was a dramatic growth in the number of economics doctorates awarded. Blacks represented one percent of doctorates awarded, 1905-1955, with the first black doctorate awarded in 1934 (**Figure 2).** Each of the six black graduates pursued careers in academia and public service. Each black graduate was nationally and internationally recognized for excellence and contributions to black communities.
- Table 1 presents maximum likelihood estimates of coefficients in the logistic model of the probability of a black Ph.D. award in economics. Test statistics reveal strong model fit.
- Statistically significant coefficients are Julius Rosenwald Fellowship (**7.369**, p =.000) and Theory dissertation (**1.7513**, p = .039). The effects of Harvard undergraduate degree or relative size of class are not statistically significant.
- Computed elasticities are: **0.08386** (Rosenwald Fellowship) and **0.1805** (Theory). Neither elasticity is greater than one, meaning that the effects are inelastic. Doubling the Rosenwald Fellowship or Theory Dissertation rates increases black doctorate rates by 8 and 18 percent.
- The key factors influencing the production of black doctorates were: scholarship funding and specialization in economic theory. But, these effects are very inelastic meaning that small changes in these factors would not have had a large impact on the supply of black Ph.Ds. in economics at Harvard.

Acknowledgements

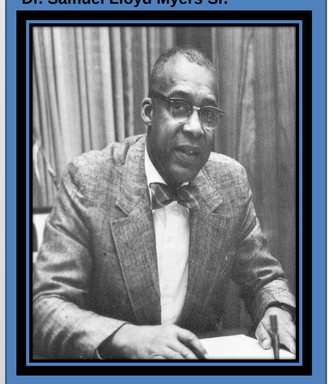
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Sir Hastings Dudley Huggins



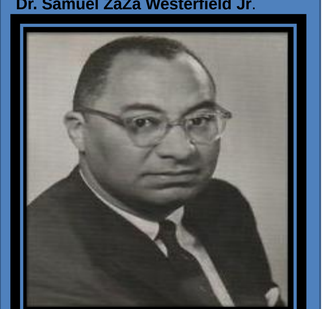
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